

Take Up Your Cross - Mark 8 (Study)

Take Up Your Cross

A Group Study on Mark 8:31-9:1

And he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and the chief priests and the scribes and be killed, and after three days rise again. And he said this plainly. And Peter took him aside and began to rebuke him. But turning and seeing his disciples, he rebuked Peter and said, "Get behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man." And calling the crowd to him with his disciples, he said to them, "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me. For whoever would save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake and the gospel's will save it. For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul? For what can a man give in return for his soul? For whoever is ashamed of me and of my words in this adulterous and sinful generation, of him will the Son of Man also be ashamed when he comes in the glory of his Father with the holy angels." And he said to them, "Truly, I say to you, there are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God after it has come in power."

Introduction

Mark wrote this Gospel for Christians in Rome during the reign of Nero. The emperor had just begun blaming believers for the Great Fire of AD 64. Christians were being crucified in public gardens. Some were being wrapped in animal skins and torn apart by dogs. Some were being burned alive as torches to light Nero's parties. When Mark put these words of Jesus down on parchment — *take up your cross and follow me* — he was not handing out a spiritual metaphor. He was handing his readers a description of what their Monday morning might look like.

That same Jesus speaks to us. Most of us will not be crucified. But the cross has a thousand shapes, and Jesus has a way of meeting people on whatever road they are actually walking.

For many of you, the cross you carry was not chosen. A body that used to work and doesn't. A husband or wife gone ahead. A child who doesn't visit. A name the nurse keeps getting wrong. A world that walks past you faster every year. You did not sign up for any of it — and yet here you are, still here, still hoping.

This passage is for people on that road. Jesus does not promise to take the cross away. He does something better. He walks ahead, he turns around, and he says: *Come behind me. I know this road. I have walked it myself.*

By the end, he promises that some of those standing there will see the Kingdom of God come in power. They did — and so will you.

Section 1: The Necessary Road (vv.31-33)

Focus: Mark 8:31-33 — *"And he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things... And Peter took him aside and began to rebuke him."*

Notes

Something new happens in verse 31. For seven chapters Mark has shown us Jesus healing, exorcising, feeding, walking on water, teaching in parables. Now, for the first time, Jesus sits his disciples down and says plainly: *I am going to be killed*.

The key word is small and easy to miss: "**must**." In Greek, it is *dei* (pronounced "day"), and it carries the weight of divine necessity. This is not "it will probably happen" or "I'm afraid it might happen." It is "this is what *must* happen, because this is what the Father has planned from the beginning." The cross is not an accident. It is not a tragedy the disciples will need to explain away later. It is the road God himself laid down, written into the Scriptures hundreds of years before Jesus was born.

Jesus names three groups who will reject him: the **elders, chief priests, and scribes**. Together they made up the Sanhedrin — the seventy-one-member ruling council in Jerusalem, led by the high priest. These were the most respected religious men in Israel. They knew their Bibles. They prayed more than most of us will pray in a lifetime. And when God himself walked into the room, they would vote to kill him.

Then Jesus says something even stranger: "and after three days rise again." He does not predict only his death. He predicts his resurrection in the same breath. The disciples apparently could not hear that second half. Peter pulls Jesus aside — *takes him aside*, as if managing him — and begins to rebuke him.

We don't know exactly what Peter said. Mark does not tell us. Maybe: "Lord, don't talk like that. You're scaring the others." Maybe: "Surely not, Lord. God will protect you." Whatever the words, the intent was protective. Peter was not trying to hurt Jesus. He was trying to spare him.

Jesus' answer is shocking: "**Get behind me, Satan!**"

Here is what that means. The Greek phrase is *hupage opisō mou* — literally, "go behind me." It is the exact same phrase Jesus used when he first called his disciples in Mark 1:17: "Come after me." Peter has left his proper position *behind* Jesus and tried to lead from the front. Jesus is not dismissing Peter. He is *repositioning* him. *You are my disciple, not my manager. Get back in line.*

And yet Jesus calls him **Satan**. Why? Because Satan had already tried this in the wilderness (Matthew 4:8-10): *there is a shortcut — you can have the kingdom without the cross*. When Peter tells Jesus to avoid suffering, he is unknowingly repeating the tempter's line. "You are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man." The word for "setting your mind" is *phroneō* — it doesn't mean "thinking about" so much as "being oriented toward, having one's allegiance set on." Peter's mind was set in the human direction: survival, success, no pain. God's mind was set on the salvation of the world through the cross.

Why this matters for us: There are times when people who love you will try to talk you out of the hard road God has put you on. They mean well. They want to spare you. But sometimes the hardest thing about the cross is not the cross itself — it is the well-meaning voice that says, "Surely it doesn't have to be this way."

Many of you have heard that voice. *Stop praying so much, Mom — you'll wear yourself out. Dad, you don't need to talk about death all the time. Grandma, church is too much for you; just rest.* Some of that is love. Some of it is Peter. Jesus teaches us to know the difference — not by dismissing the ones who love us, but by quietly keeping our face toward the road God has us on. The road to Jerusalem is a *must*. The road through old age, through loss, through the shadow of death — Jesus has walked it. He knows the way. He goes ahead of you.

Reflection Questions

1. Has anyone, out of love, tried to talk you out of something you knew God was asking of you? How did you tell the difference between their care and God's call?
2. Jesus predicted his death and his resurrection in the same breath, but the disciples only heard the first half. When you think about the road ahead, how easy or hard is it to remember both the cross *and* the rising?

Section 2: Deny, Take Up, Follow (vv.34-37)

Focus: Mark 8:34-37 — *"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me."*

Notes

Now Mark's camera pulls back. Up to verse 34, Jesus has been talking only to the Twelve. Now he calls the **crowd** — and Mark makes a point of telling us. This is not private teaching for insiders. This is public. Cross-bearing is not for the spiritual elite. It is for whoever will come.

Three verbs follow, and the order matters:

1. Deny yourself. The Greek word is *aparneomai* — to disown, to renounce. It is the exact word Peter will use three times on the night Jesus is arrested: *I do not know the man* (Mark 14:30, 72). Jesus uses it first, and uses it against the self: *disown yourself before you find yourself disowning me*. This is not self-hatred. It is not saying you are worthless. It is saying: *I am not in charge here. Someone better is*. It is taking the crown off your own head and putting it where it belongs.

2. Take up your cross. In the first century, this phrase had only one meaning. When the Romans crucified someone, the condemned man was forced to carry his own crossbeam — the horizontal piece, the *patibulum*, weighing 75 to 125 pounds — from the prison to the execution site. He walked through jeering crowds, stripped of dignity, already a dead man. That is the picture Jesus paints. "Take up your cross" meant "start walking toward your own death."

For most of Jesus' first hearers, this would have sounded like insanity. For Mark's Roman readers, it was a photograph of their own week. For us today, the cross has become a necklace, a tattoo, a logo. We need to pull the word back toward what it originally meant before we can hear Jesus correctly.

3. Follow me. The Greek here changes gears. The first two verbs — deny, take up — are in the aorist tense. That means a decisive, once-for-all act. Settle it. But "**follow**" is in the present tense — continuous, ongoing, day after day after day. Denial and cross-taking are turning points. Following is a way of walking, and you will walk it tomorrow, and the next day, and the next.

Then Jesus explains the paradox. "Whoever would save his life will lose it; whoever loses his life for my sake and the gospel's will save it." The Greek word for "life" here is *psychē* — it means both the physical life (what you breathe with) and the true self (who you really are). Jesus is making a deliberate pun. If you spend your life protecting your life, you will lose the self you were meant to be. If you spend your life for Christ, you will find — on the other side of losing — the self he made you to be.

And then come the two questions, spoken in the language of the marketplace: "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul? What can a man give in return for his soul?" The word for "exchange" is *antallagma* — the price in a trade. Jesus is saying: put the entire world on one side of the scale

and one human soul on the other, and the soul tips it. There is no sum of money, no accomplishment, no amount of comfort, that can be traded for a soul. The soul is priceless. Only God himself, at the cross, will pay what your soul is worth.

Why this matters for us: Here is what is strange and beautiful about this passage for those of you in this room. The Lord is not asking you to pick up a cross you do not have. Many of you are already carrying one. The body that aches. The memory that slips. The friend you buried. The independence you lost. *You did not choose this cross. But Jesus is on this road.*

The question is not whether you will carry it. You already are. The question is whether you will carry it *behind him*. Self-pity carries the cross alone. Faith carries it in the footsteps of the One who carried his for you. The cross you cannot avoid becomes, in Christ, a cross that joins you to him.

And consider what you have seen across a long life. You have watched people spend themselves chasing the world — a bigger house, a bigger title, a bigger reputation. Some of them gained it. Some did not. You know, better than any younger person could know, that none of it could be traded for a soul. Your silent life of prayer in this chair is worth more than a skyscraper with your name on it. Jesus weighed the scales. You know he is right.

Reflection Questions

1. Jesus tells us to take up a cross. Many of you are already carrying one that you did not choose. What would it look like to carry it *with* Jesus rather than alone?
2. You have watched a whole generation chase after "the world." What have you come to understand about the worth of a soul that a younger person might not yet see?

Section 3: Not Ashamed, Kingdom Come (v.38-9:1)

Focus: Mark 8:38-9:1 — *"Whoever is ashamed of me... of him will the Son of Man also be ashamed when he comes in the glory of his Father... Truly, I say to you, there are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God after it has come in power."*

Notes

The passage ends with two promises — a warning and a hope.

The warning. "Whoever is ashamed of me and of my words." The word "ashamed" is *epaischynomai* — a word that carries weight in the ancient world we can barely feel today. In Jesus' time and in Mark's Roman world, your public reputation was your life's most valuable asset. To be ashamed of someone was to disown them in public. To refuse to use their name. To pretend, when others were watching, that you didn't know them.

And Jesus says: *If you disown me now, I will disown you then.* The day will come when the Son of Man will appear "in the glory of his Father with the holy angels" — the picture is from Daniel 7, the final courtroom scene. And in that scene, Jesus says, he will look at the people who were embarrassed by him here, and he will say: *I don't know them.*

That is sobering. But consider who Mark's first readers were. Roman Christians, some of whom had already denied Jesus once to save their skins — the way Peter did. Mark is not shaming them. He is calling them back. *Don't live ashamed of him. He is not ashamed of you.*

Think about our own generation. Jesus' name gets easier to avoid every year. In many hallways, in many families, at many holiday tables, it is politely expected that you will not mention him. Your faith is permitted — so long as you keep it to yourself. Many of you have felt it. You keep a Bible by your chair. You pray for your grandchildren. But when the conversation turns to real things, the name of Jesus sticks in your throat. The culture has trained you to whisper where you should have spoken.

Jesus says: *Don't*. Not angry, not loud, not argumentative — just not ashamed. Your soft voice speaking his name in a hallway is heard in heaven. The courts of glory will remember it.

The hope. Then comes one of the most striking promises in the Gospel: "**Truly, I say to you, there are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God after it has come in power.**"

At first reading, this has puzzled Christians for centuries. Didn't the disciples die without seeing the Kingdom? Didn't Jesus mis-predict? No — and the key is one small word the ESV translates carefully: "after it has come." The Greek verb *elēlythyian* is in the perfect tense, which in Greek means "already arrived and still standing." Jesus is not saying some will see the Kingdom *begin to come*. He is saying some will see the Kingdom *having already come, in full power*.

And just six verses later — Mark 9:2 — three of those disciples (Peter, James, and John) climb a mountain with Jesus. He is transfigured before them. His face shines. His clothes become dazzling white. Moses and Elijah appear. A cloud descends. A voice speaks: *This is my beloved Son; listen to him*. They see, for a moment, what the Kingdom looks like at full volume. And then, through the resurrection, through Pentecost, through the birth of the Church — the Kingdom keeps breaking in. The disciples lived to see more of it than they ever dreamed.

This is not only for them. The Kingdom has *already* come in power. It came when the tomb was empty. It came when the Spirit fell at Pentecost. It comes every time a sinner is saved, a prayer is answered, a saint dies in peace. It is not merely on the horizon. It is already at work. The final unveiling is still to come — but the power has already arrived.

Why this matters for us: Many of you are standing closer to the veil than most of us. You have already watched more friends enter the presence of the Lord than you can count. You have sat by beds where the last breath was drawn. You know — not in theory, but in experience — that the edge of this world is thinner than the young ever imagine.

Jesus' promise in 9:1 is for you. The Kingdom has *already* come in power. The resurrection has *already* happened. Christ is *already* reigning. You are not waiting for proof. You are waiting for the veil to lift. Many of you will see it very soon. For some in this room, "those standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God" is not a puzzle from the first century. It is a promise for this afternoon.

And when that day comes — when you step across — you will not find that you were wrong. You will find that you did not see the half of it.

Reflection Questions

1. Where, in your life right now, do you feel pressure to be quiet about Jesus? What would it look like to gently, not ashamed, say his name in one of those places this week?
2. Jesus promises that the Kingdom has *already* come in power. Where have you seen evidence of that across your lifetime — moments where God's power broke in?

3. For many of you, the veil between this world and the next feels thin. How does it comfort you that the Kingdom is *already* there, not just *coming*?

For Reflection

This week, try two things:

First: Name one cross you are already carrying — something about your life right now that you did not choose and cannot change. Say it out loud to the Lord. Then pray one simple prayer: *Jesus, I am not carrying this alone. I am carrying it behind you.* Let the image of him walking ahead on the same road settle into you.

Second: Speak Jesus' name once this week in a place where silence would be easier. To a grandchild on the phone. To a nurse. To the person across the table at lunch. You do not have to argue. You do not have to preach. Just say his name. Let him be real in one more room than he was last week.

Peter tried to spare Jesus the cross, and Jesus called it the work of Satan. The world will still try to spare you the cross. Your job is to keep walking — behind him, not ahead of him. The road is hard. The road is necessary. And the road ends at a sight your eyes have been waiting your whole life to see.

"There are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God after it has come in power."

Right here. Right now. For whoever will follow.

Key Terms at a Glance

English (ESV)	Greek	Meaning
"Must" (suffer)	<i>dei</i>	A small but heavy word — "it is necessary," the divine necessity. The cross is not accident; it is plan.
"Plainly"	<i>parrēsia</i>	Openly, frankly. Jesus stops speaking in parables about his death and says it straight.
"Get behind me"	<i>hupage opisō mou</i>	Literally "go behind me" — the same phrase as "come after me" in Mark 1:17. Not dismissal; repositioning.
"Satan"	<i>Satanas</i>	Hebrew for "adversary." Peter is not the devil, but his words come from the same playbook.
"Setting your mind on"	<i>phroneō</i>	Not just thinking about — being oriented toward, giving your allegiance to.
"Deny himself"	<i>aparneomai</i>	To disown, renounce. Same word Peter uses three times on the night of the arrest.
"Cross"	<i>stauros</i>	Not jewelry — the Roman execution beam. "Take up your cross" meant "walk toward your own death."
"Life / soul"	<i>psychē</i>	Both physical life <i>and</i> the true self. Jesus uses the pun on purpose.
"Give in exchange"	<i>antallagma</i>	A marketplace word — the price in a trade. The soul cannot be traded.

English (ESV)	Greek	Meaning
"Ashamed"	<i>epaischynomai</i>	To disown someone publicly; the opposite of confessing them.
"After it has come"	<i>elēlythian</i>	A perfect tense participle — not "about to come" but "already arrived and still here in power."

Passage Structure at a Glance

THE PREDICTION (v.31)

- The Son of Man **MUST** suffer, be rejected, be killed, and rise
- "Must" = divine necessity. The cross is plan, not accident.

THE REBUKE (vv.32-33)

- Jesus speaks plainly
- Peter rebukes Jesus (from the front)
- Jesus rebukes Peter (back to his proper place)
- "Things of God" vs. "things of men"

THE CALL TO THE CROWD (v.34)

- Deny yourself (decisive – once for all)
- Take up your cross (decisive – once for all)
- Follow me (continuous – day after day)

THE PARADOX (vv.35-37)

- Save your life → lose it
- Lose your life for Jesus' sake → save it
- The whole world cannot be traded for one soul

THE WARNING AND THE HOPE (v.38-9:1)

- Ashamed of Jesus now → Jesus ashamed of you then
- But: some standing here will see the Kingdom come in power – and they did.

ANCHOR: The Kingdom has **ALREADY** come. We are not waiting for proof. We are waiting for the veil to lift.